Cast:
Evangeline: Mrs. Roberts
Alice: Susan, Eleanor Roosevelt
Evonne: Marian Anderson

SCENE 1: HISTORICAL CONTEXT

(There is suddenly a knock from backstage. Roberts opens the door but doesn't see anyone until Susan jumps out from behind.)

Mrs. Robert: "Oh, Susan, can you believe that I received another letter asking if we, the Daughters of the American Revolution, would book Marion Anderson for Constitution Hall on April 9, 1939, this time from the Secretary of the Interior, Secretary Ike's?"

Susan: "Marian Anderson? Mrs. Roberts, are you talking about the colored opera singer!? Oh, wouldn't that be wonderful-

Mrs. Robert: "But we cannot accept her! Think of the white performers-only policy that we enacted seven years ago!"

Susan: (after a pause) "But can't we make an exception considering she's backed by Howard University and Secretary Ickes? After all, she has performed for royalty in Europe. Is there any way that you as the president of the DAR could propose a change at our upcoming board meeting?"

Mrs. Robert: I'll consider discussing this at the meeting, but I doubt any of our members will want the change. ~~O~~ur constitution states that "the object of our society is to perpetuate the memory and the spirit of the men and women who achieved American Independence. Part of that perpetuation means preserving our Anglo-Saxon heritage; and how are we able to do that by violating our white-performers policy?"

Susan: "We do need to honor the ideas of racial purity, but don't you think that we should prioritize our nation's founding documents first? The Declaration of Independence declares that all men are created eq-…

Mrs. Robert: (look a little annoyed) "Susan, the question is one of differing philosophies. We believe the spirit of American Democracy rests with the descendants of the original revolutionaries - and those descendants are white, (side-eye Evangeline)
but I suppose your plan does no harm; I shall write back to Secretary Ickes as soon as we get the decision of the board."

END OF SCENE 1

SCENE 2: Rejection + Eleanor Roosevelt

Marian Anderson:

“Dear Miss Marian Anderson,

It is with much regret that we inform you that you will not be able to perform at Constitution Hall this Easter Sunday. The DAR management has informed us that the Hall has prior booking commitments and that they desire to stay true to their… white performers only policy and are unable to exempt you.

“And here it is in the morning edition for everyone to read before I even open my mail.

(Enter Eleanor Roosevelt from stage left, holding a newspaper.)

Eleanor Roosevelt:

Tell her Mrs Roosevelt says thank you, dear!

(Puts glasses on and opens newspaper)

“Despite much media backlash, the daughters of the revolution stand firm in their decision that they are unable to host famed contralto Marian Anderson in Constitution Hall…”

I don’t believe this. I thought we lived in a country where we judged people for their skill and hard work, not for the color of their skin. (have a dramatic pause, shaking your head) I suppose the DAR no longer remembers the principles of our Declaration of Independence

But no, I shouldn’t get involved. Confrontation will do anyone any benefit, but I know I can no longer stand with the DAR.

Dear Mrs. Roberts

“I am afraid that I have never been a very useful member of the DAR, so I know it will make very little difference whether I resign…(pause as if thinking what to write next) However, I am in complete disagreement with the attitude taken in refusing Constitution Hall to a great artist. You had an opportunity to lead in an enlightened way,

(Mrs. Roberts comes in here holding the letter that Roosevelt is writing)
and it seems to me that your organization has failed. Very sincerely yours, Eleanor Roosevelt.”

(Mrs. Roberts picks up newspaper)

Mrs. Roberts: She wrote of this in her My Day column as well!? How preposterous that she would bring such private affairs into the public eye!”

(Evangeline storms off and Evonne nails a protest poster on the left and then the right) 6:18

End Scene 2

Scene 3: Mrs. Roberts (DAR) and American Backlash

(Mrs. Roberts storms onto the stage frantically)

Mrs. Roberts: Oh, why are there so many papers?

(Mrs. Roberts picks up the top letter from the stack and looks at it as a voice from the back reads out the headline.)

Alice: I want to express my unqualified loyalty to the DAR and my faith in the action of its board in reference to Marian Anderson. Art may be art, but rules and laws are higher still…Signed, May Whitney

(Mrs. Roberts nods along approvingly and in relief, kinda like her saying just so just so)

Evonne: That this great singer, Marian Anderson, is being barred only because she is colored, there is no question. Is it possible that the Daughters of the American Revolution have never heard of the five thousand Negroes who fought in the American Revolution?

Mrs. Roberts says hesitantly: But this is from The Atlanta Daily World; of course the colored newspaper would support their own people!

Alice: "I am well acquainted with the Negro question. Still, I consider it inappropriate for the DAR to refuse Miss **Anderson** a place to sing. Therefore, I, Dr. Elsi Mitchell, can no longer lead the San Francisco DAR chapter.

(Mrs. Roberts looks in shock at the decision; she is unsure of what to think of the backlash from white people)

Evonne: "The only possible reason for your organization's refusal is Miss **Anderson's** color. Such action is so consonant with Nazi and Fascist philosophy that it is indeed shocking to find it emanating from an organization supposed to preserve and foster American principles of government."

Mrs. Roberts sits down at her desk almost in a daze: …But we were simply preserving the racial ideals of the past; are those ideals really in conflict with the founding principles of our country?

Scene 4: Eleanor Roosevelt meets Marian Anderson to ask her to sing at the Lincoln Memorial

(Setting is Eleanor's house. Eleanor takes off the protest poster and reads it)

Eleanor Roosevelt (Turning with a warm smile): Miss Anderson, thank you for coming. I know the last few weeks have been rather hectic considering the protests done by the Marian Anderson Citizens Committee on your behalf.

Marian Anderson: It has indeed been a difficult time, Mrs. Roosevelt. I only ever wanted to sing…(bitter smile).

Eleanor Roosevelt (nodding): I know. And that is why it is important to me that you *do* sing. I have spoken with Franklin, my dear. While he must tread carefully with the demands of his position, he has given full approval to a plan proposed by Secretary Ickes.

Marian Anderson (curious): A plan?

Eleanor Roosevelt: Franklin has authorized the use of the Lincoln Memorial! You'll sing from the steps. Will you do it?"

Marian Anderson (at first hesitating and then straightening her posture, a look of resolve growing): If you and the President believe I am worthy of such a stage,(smile)... then I will sing with everything I have.
3:33
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My Country 'Tis of Thee
My country, 'tis of thee,
Sweet land of liberty,
Of thee I sing;
Land where my fathers died,
Land of the pilgrims' pride,
From ev'ry mountainside
Let freedom ring!

(5:45)
Evangeline: On April 9th, nearly 75 thousand people came to attend Miss Anderson's performance, and millions heard her voice over the radio. On July 2, that same year, Eleanor Roosevelt personally awarded her the Spingarn medal, an award presented by the NAACP for

exceptional achievements accomplished by African American individuals. The DAR too eventually came to REFORM after the backlash, putting out a formal apology and allowing Ms. Anderson to perform in Constitution Hall in 1943 for the troops fighting in World War II.

Alice: For longer impacts, Marian Anderson's performance set the stage for the revolution in civil rights. The symbolism was famously realized in 1963 when she would sing "He's Got the Whole World in His Hands" on the same steps where Martin Luther King Jr. gave his "I Have a Dream" speech during his March on Washington.

Evangeline: The impact on King was personal as he was in attendance at the 1939 concert with his father; he reflected on this experience in a prize-winning 1944 oratorical essay:

(Put on blazer)

" Marian Anderson was barred from singing in the Constitution Hall, ironically enough, by the professional daughters of the very men who founded this nation for liberty and equality. But this tale had a different ending. The nation rose in protest and gave a stunning rebuke to the Daughters of the American Revolution and a tremendous ovation to the artist, Marian Anderson, who sang fittingly before the Lincoln Memorial"

Evangeline: Ultimately, this event demonstrated that the government could be an ally in the fight for human dignity and Civil Rights reform, and showed the world that Black excellence was a public, foundational part of the American identity. As the DAR recently stated, "Ms. Anderson's legendary concert will always be remembered as a milestone in the Civil Rights movement."

Alice: On the other hand, history shows that the DAR, though rightfully considered the antagonists, were defending ideas they deemed essential to their organization: the ideal of racial purity attributed to the original revolutionary actors. However, in doing so, they sacrificed the principles upon which America was founded: the idea that "all men are created equal." Therefore, this historical event is not simply a racial conflict, but also a clash of philosophies posing the question of how we as a country can be careful in choosing which ideas from the past we apply to an ever-changing future. And as Miss Marian Anderson said in her own words at the time:

Evonne: “*I don’t like a lot of show, and one could not tell in advance what direction the affair would take… I could see that my significance as an individual was small in this affair. I had become, whether I liked it or not, a symbol, representing my people. I had to appear.*”